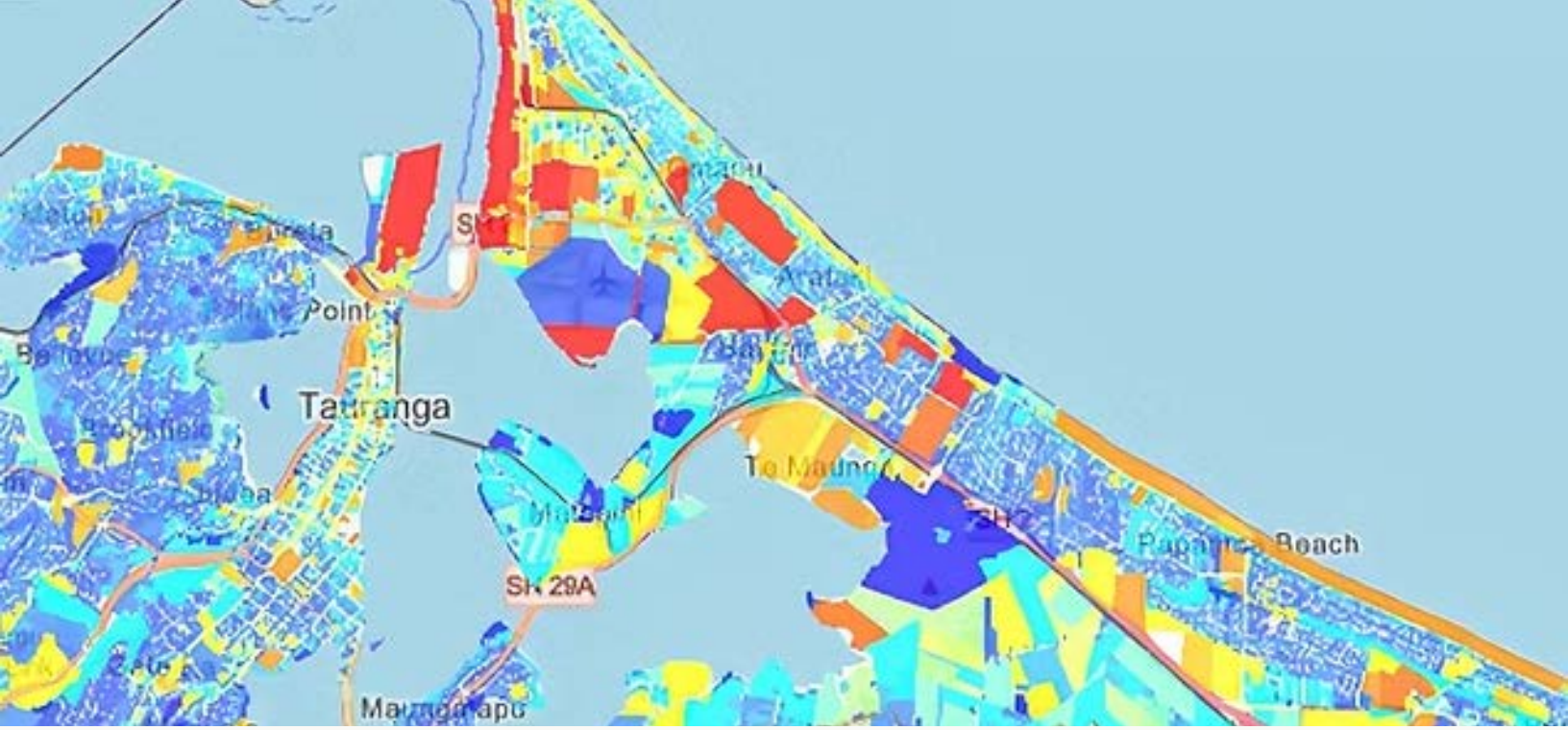


# Essential planning guide to **rural** home building in the Bay of Plenty

Considering building a rural lifestyle home in the Bay of Plenty? Here's what you need to know — a checklist of the unique features to keep in mind, and how our free Architecture + Build Service can do the leg work for you.

THORNE GROUP




01

## Geotechnical

Rural land that has been developed for residential housing should have an accompanying Geotech Investigation Report outlining the condition and stability of the ground and nominating a building area for construction. The report should include recommendations for foundation design, which can significantly affect cost. The accompanying site plan should indicate the required boundary setbacks and any build restriction lines. Locating the house outside of the nominated building area will require additional Geotech investigation and analysis.



02

## Resource consent

If your intended build project does not comply with the rules of the City or District Plan, the project will require a Resource Consent. A Resource Consent application is typically required if the site is within a coastal inundation area or in close proximity to a river or waterway, if you intend to build closer to the boundary than the current setback allows, or you intend to build more than one dwelling.



03

## Foundations, earthworks and retaining

Ground conditions as outlined in the Geotech Report will generally determine the type of foundations suitable for the site. Depending on the contours of the site, positioning the home to achieve the ideal finished floor level may require substantial earthworks and/or retaining to provide a level building platform. If raising the site to take in views is part of your brief, you need to factor this into your overall budget.



04

## Utilities

In most instances, supply of power and telecomms to the property boundary is a given. However, there can be unexpected cost if there is insufficient capacity within the power network for a new connection, or if there is an extended distance between the boundary connection and the proposed house site. While the rollout of fibre to rural areas throughout NZ is ongoing, many rural properties are reliant on a satellite provider like Starlink for high-speed internet.



05

## Soil contamination and waterway protection

Rural sites that have been developed for housing could potentially have contaminated soils from previous land use. We recommend checking the Land Use Register with the local council for information about prior use of the property. Land that has been identified as having (or potentially having) contaminated soil will require an NES (National Environmental Standard) Report outlining controls for managing contaminants in the soil.

If your site has nearby streams or rivers, it's vital to protect these natural resources. Proper planning ensures your property won't negatively impact the water quality, keeping the local ecosystem healthy.



06

## Archaeological

Rural sites can sometimes be located within proximity of a registered archaeological site. In some instances, an inspection by a qualified archaeologist may be required and an Archaeological Authority recommended. If any items of archaeological significance are identified during excavation, the process to assess and remove them will require input from an archaeologist specialist.



07

## Access

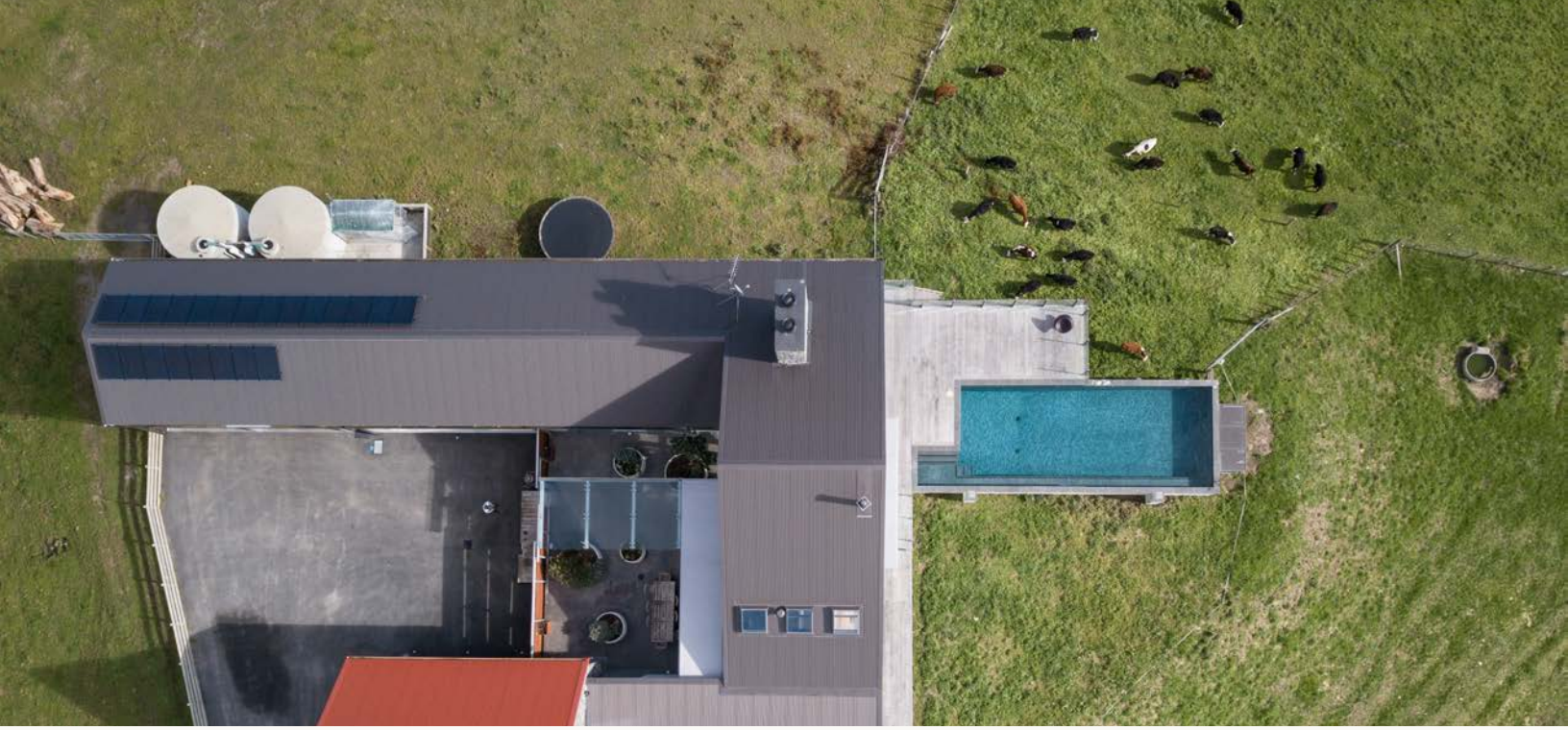
It's easy to overlook, but you'll want a durable and accessible roadway to your home that can handle year-round weather conditions. If your site is subject to Resource Consent conditions, there may be specific requirements for constructing private rights of way.



08

## Septic tanks

Generally council sewer connections are not available in rural areas, which means you will need to factor in an onsite effluent disposal solution. Rural sites require site-specific wastewater management systems to be designed by an accredited environmental engineer and sized specifically to meet the needs of the site and its occupants. In most cases a traditional septic tank system with soakage trenches is no longer sufficient, with more advanced eco systems now required for most sites. The location of the effluent disposal field is a key consideration in site planning. This needs to be considered in your overall project budget.



09

## Water supply

Rural properties may not have access to council-supplied water and need to rely on rainwater harvesting and storage systems for potable water for domestic use. This needs to be considered as part of your Stormwater Management Design, taking into account things like the consumption needs for the number of occupants in the home, storage capacity, tank type and location, and additional requirements such as a pool or firefighting supply. The location of storage tanks, particularly above-ground tanks, is a key planning consideration ensuring compliance with any site covenants. Having a reliable and sustainable water supply is critical to ensure there's enough water to meet your needs, even in drier months.



10

## Stormwater management

Rural areas can be prone to unpredictable weather, particularly during heavy rainfall, and managing water disbursement is essential to prevent flooding. It's crucial to have proper drainage systems in place to handle rainwater collection and stormwater run-off. Rural sites require site-specific stormwater management systems designed by an accredited environmental engineer. This needs to be considered in your overall project budget.



11

# Energy solutions

With the cost of generating and supplying electricity continuing to rise, more people are turning to solar power solutions for self-sufficiency and to help manage energy costs. Solar systems are a significant investment, and in most cases battery storage is necessary to gain the most benefit. A well-designed system will take into account the number of people living in the property and their likely energy requirements for lighting, hot water, heating/cooling, appliances and EV charging. If you are installing a pool, then heating the pool to extend the swimming season is another consideration. While solar systems can be retrofitted, installing as part of the build project is cheaper and more efficient. In remote rural areas, where grid electricity supply is unreliable, a back-up generator may also be recommended.



12

# Outdoor living

What good is a rural site without being able to take in the views and enjoy the serenity. Elevated rural sites can be exposed to prevailing winds and weather, so ensure there are one or two sheltered spots within your design. Features like sliding screens, retractable blinds and louvres can extend the use of outdoor spaces year-round. To make the most of your rural property, consider, as part of your overall site plan, facilities that extend beyond the immediate house footprint like an outdoor fire or fire pit, outdoor kitchen and cooking facilities (BBQ, pizza oven) and seating. It's a great way to enjoy the scenery and make your home feel even more connected to nature. Even if you intend to take a staged approach to developing your rural site, having an overall vision at the outset enables you to plan for future development by running services like power and water to specific locations on the property.



13

# Insulation and heating

Comfort is key, especially in rural settings, and this starts with good design. Orientating the home so that living spaces face north for passive solar gain, including wide eaves providing shade in summer, combined with modern insulation and thermally broken window joinery goes a long way to creating a home that provides year-round comfort. Factoring in an energy-efficient heating and cooling system will ensure your home is warm in winter and cool in summer, without skyrocketing energy bills.



/ RIVER VIEWS

INSPIRATION

# Rural homes we have **built**.

Complex sites across the Bay of Plenty. Each one designed for its land, its climate and the people who live there.



/ BETHLEHEM FAMILY HAVEN



/ HILLTOP HAVEN



/ KAIMAI VIEWS



/ MODERN COUNTRY

/ COUNTRY VISTA





NEXT STEPS

# The earlier we talk, the more **useful** we can be.

There are numerous considerations with planning a rural build. If you would like help mapping out next steps, enquire about our Architecture + Build Service and free site assessment. We will talk you through any obstacles or hazards, consents and costs, and recommend the most efficient way to build a rural home that will last.

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